

First-Year Nurse Survival Guide

What Nursing School Didn't Teach You

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Chapter 1: The First 90 Days

What to Expect

Your first 90 days will be the hardest of your career. You'll question whether you made the right choice. You'll cry in the bathroom. You'll have moments where you stare at a patient's chart and have no idea what to do.

This is normal. Every experienced nurse went through it.

The Learning Curve

Timeframe	What You'll Feel	Reality
Week 1	Overwhelmed, excited	You're drinking from a fire hose
Month 1	Incompetent, anxious	You're learning systems, not skills
Month 2-3	Frustrated, plateaued	This is normal — keep going
Month 6	Competent but cautious	You're becoming a nurse
Year 1	Confident(ish)	You know what you don't know
Year 2+	Comfortable	You can handle most situations

Daily Survival Checklist

Before Shift:

- ☐ Sleep >6 hours (ideally 7-8)
- ☐ Eat something
- ☐ Caffeine (let's be honest)
- ☐ Arrive 15 minutes early

During Shift:

- ☐ Get report, identify priorities
- ☐ Check orders immediately
- ☐ Assess your sickest patient first
- ☐ Cluster care when possible
- ☐ Document as you go (don't wait until end)
- ☐ Take breaks (you're legally entitled)
- ☐ Ask for help before you're drowning

After Shift:

- ☐ Give thorough report
 - ☐ Complete documentation
 - ☐ Leave work at work
 - ☐ Do something for yourself
 - ☐ Sleep
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Chapter 2: Time Management for New Grads

The Time Block Method

New grads struggle with time because everything takes longer. Use this method:

Hour 1 (0700-0800):

- Get report (15 min)
- Check orders, labs, meds (15 min)
- Assess all patients (30 min) — quick rounds

Hour 2-3 (0800-1000):

- Med pass for patients who need morning meds
- Morning assessments (detailed)
- Delegate what you can

Hour 4-5 (1000-1200):

- Procedures, dressing changes
- Patient education
- Documentation

Hour 6-7 (1200-1400):

- Lunch (take it)
- Afternoon meds
- Reassessments

Hour 8-9 (1400-1600):

- Discharge planning
- Admission prep
- Family updates

Hour 10-12 (1600-1900):

- End-of-shift meds
- Final assessments
- Documentation
- Give report

The "What If Everything Goes Wrong" Plan

Sometimes you fall behind. Here's what to do:

1. **Triage your tasks** — What MUST be done? What can wait?
2. **Ask for help** — Charge nurse, other nurses, techs
3. **Delegate** — What can someone else do?

4. **Communicate** — Tell your patients you'll be late
 5. **Document later** — Patient care > documentation (but document!)
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Chapter 3: Building Clinical Intuition

The Pattern Recognition Game

Experienced nurses seem to "just know" when something is wrong. This isn't magic. It's pattern recognition from seeing thousands of patients.

You can accelerate this:

Every shift, ask yourself:

1. What was the most interesting case today?
2. What did I learn?
3. What would I do differently?
4. What pattern did I see?

Keep a nursing journal. Write down:

- Interesting cases
- Mistakes (yes, write them down)
- What your preceptor/mentor taught you
- Questions you had

Review it monthly. You'll see your growth.

The "Something Is Wrong" Feeling

Trust your gut. If a patient "just doesn't look right," investigate. Experienced nurses have saved lives by acting on a vague feeling.

What to check when you have that feeling:

- Vitals (including trend)
 - Mental status
 - Skin color/temperature
 - Work of breathing
 - Urine output (if applicable)
 - Pain level
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Chapter 4: Documentation That Protects Your License

The Golden Rules

1. **If you didn't document it, you didn't do it.**
2. **Document objectively, not judgmentally.**
 - Good: "Patient refused medication. Educated on purpose. States understanding. Still refusing."
 - Bad: "Patient being difficult and refused meds."
3. **Document conversations with providers.**
 - "Called Dr. Smith at 1430 regarding elevated BP. Orders received: [list]."
4. **Document falls, injuries, incidents immediately.**
5. **Never document ahead of time.**

6. **Never alter documentation after the fact.**

Documentation Templates

Medication Administration:

0815: Tylenol 650mg PO given for headache 6/10.
Patient tolerated. No adverse effects.
0945: Patient reports headache improved to 2/10.

Patient Refusal:

1015: Lasix 40mg PO offered. Patient refused.
Reason: "I don't like how it makes me pee."
Educated on importance for CHF management.
Patient verbalizes understanding. Still refusing.
MD notified. No new orders.

Provider Notification:

1430: Called Dr. Jones regarding BP 188/102.
Patient asymptomatic. Orders: Labetalol 10mg IV push now.
Recheck BP in 30 minutes. Call if >180/100.

Chapter 5: Handling Burnout

The Signs

- Dreading work
- Emotional exhaustion
- Cynicism about patients
- Reduced sense of accomplishment
- Physical symptoms (headaches, GI issues, insomnia)

Prevention Strategies

Physical:

- Sleep 7-8 hours
- Exercise (even 20 minutes)
- Eat real food
- Hydrate

Emotional:

- Talk to someone (therapist, friend, colleague)
- Set boundaries (don't pick up every extra shift)
- Find meaning (remember why you became a nurse)
- Take your PTO

Professional:

- Find a mentor
- Join a professional organization
- Learn new skills (keeps work interesting)

- Consider specialty changes if stagnant

When to Leave a Job

- Unsafe staffing ratios consistently
- Toxic culture that doesn't improve
- No support for new grads
- Physical/mental health suffering
- You've outgrown the opportunity

It's okay to leave. Your license and well-being matter more than loyalty to a bad employer.

Chapter 6: Career Advancement

Certifications to Consider (After 1-2 Years)

- CCRN (Critical Care)
- OCN (Oncology)
- PCCN (Progressive Care)
- CMSRN (Medical-Surgical)
- CEN (Emergency)

Graduate School Paths

- MSN (education, administration, informatics)
- DNP (nurse practitioner, clinical practice)
- PhD (research, academia)

Specialty Areas With High Demand

- Critical Care (ICU, ER)
 - OR/PACU
 - Oncology
 - Cardiac Cath Lab
 - Informatics
 - Case Management
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Chapter 7: The Obioma Framework for Clinical Success

Daily Mental Model

MORNING:

Who is my sickest patient?	
What could go wrong today?	
What do I need to know?	

DURING SHIFT:

Is this patient getting better or	
worse?	
What changed?	
Do I need help?	

END OF SHIFT:

| What did I learn today?
| What would I do differently?
| What am I proud of?

Final Thoughts

Your first year is about survival. Your second year is about competence. Your third year is about confidence.

You'll make mistakes. Everyone does. What matters is that you learn from them, ask for help, and keep showing up.

Nursing is hard. But it's also one of the most meaningful things you can do with your life.

You chose this. You can do this. And you're not alone.

— Nnamdi

This guide is included in the Clinical Judgment Mastery System. For the complete system with frameworks, case studies, and video walkthroughs, visit obiomacare.com